

communists' ability to strike anywhere, at any time—and inflict huge damage—thereby forcing the Americans to the negotiating table.

Choosing their moment

In the fall of 1967, growing antiwar sentiment in the United States, as well as the continued unpopularity of President Nguyen Van Thieu and his corrupt regime in Saigon, encouraged North Vietnam's leadership to believe the time was ripe to launch a full-scale attack. There was also a growing fear that North Vietnam—its economy in shambles due to the ongoing American bombing—might soon lack the resources to achieve a military solution to the conflict.

The initial plan of attack was drawn up by the Central Office for South Vietnam (COSVN), the high command responsible for coordinating communist military activities south of the DMZ. In October 1967, the politburo in Hanoi approved implementation of a “general offensive-general uprising,” a large-scale attack that would spark a mass uprising and topple the Thieu government. General Van Tien Dung made the plan operational. The only way to strike at so many places along such a broad front was a coordinated action by NVA regulars and Viet Cong guerrillas. The planners also decided that the best time to launch the assault was over Tet, the Vietnamese New Year (at the end of January), when a ceasefire would be in place across South Vietnam and many ARVN troops would be on leave.

In preparation for the offensive, the NVA bolstered its own arsenal and began resupplying the Viet Cong with arms. Through the fall of 1967, men and equipment began moving down the Ho Chi Minh Trail in ever-greater volume.